Congressional Research Service
Informing the legislative debate since 1914

Connecting Constituents to Information About Census Bureau Surveys: Frequently Asked Questions

September 30, 2026

Congressional Research Service
https://crsreports.congress.gov
R49421

CRS REPORT
Prepared for Members and
Committees of Congress

Congressional Research Service
Informing the legislative debate since 1914

SUMMARY

R49421

September 30, 2026

Taylor R. Knoedl
Analyst in American National Government

Connecting Constituents to Information About Census Bureau Surveys: Frequently Asked Questions

The U.S. Census Bureau produces statistics on demographic and economic characteristics across the United States based on more than 130 different surveys, including the agency's largest products: the decennial census and the American Community Survey (ACS).

Data from the decennial census are used for apportioning seats in the House of Representatives as well as for redistricting in the states. Other uses for census data include informing various policy decisions, guiding federal funding, offering the public insights on population trends, and helping the private sector make informed business decisions. To produce the statistics used in its data products, the Census Bureau surveys and samples the population of the United States and its territories.

For these reasons, constituents across states and congressional districts may have questions regarding the Census Bureau and the surveys it conducts. This FAQ is intended to provide information on these potential questions to support district and state staff and other staff that interact with constituents in fielding questions on these topics.

This report addresses several Census Bureau-related topics that may be of particular interest to constituents, including, but not limited to, how constituents may be contacted by the Census Bureau, how collected data are used, how data are kept private, and how Census data and other products can be accessed.

Contents

What is the U.S. Census Bureau? 1
Why and how might the Census Bureau contact my constituents? 1
How can my constituents tell if someone contacting them from the Census Bureau is legitimate? 1
- Verify a Mailing 2
- Verify an Email or Text Message 2
- Verify a Census Bureau Field Representative 2
- Verify a Phone Call 2

Are my constituents required to respond to Census Bureau surveys? Are there consequences for not responding? 3
Can the Census Bureau provide monetary incentives to survey respondents? 3
What happens with my constituents' information after the Census Bureau collects it? 4
How does the Census Bureau protect a respondent's privacy? 4
What is the American Community Survey? 5
How is the American Community Survey different from the decennial census? 5
What is the Household Trends and Outlooks Pulse Survey? 6
There has been a considerable change in population in my state or district since the last decennial census. Can the Census Bureau conduct a new count to address this change? 7
- The urban or rural classification of a community in my state or district has changed under Census Bureau delineations, potentially changing its eligibility for certain federal funding. Can this be changed? 8

How can my constituents find Census Bureau data? 8
Are there any employment opportunities available at the Census Bureau that may be relevant for my constituents? 9

Tables

Table 1. Differences Between the American Community Survey and the Decennial Census 6

Contacts

Author Information 9

What is the U.S. Census Bureau?

The U.S. Census Bureau is a federal statistical agency housed within the Department of Commerce. It is tasked with producing statistics on demographic and economic characteristics across the United States through more than 130 different surveys, including the agency's largest surveys, the decennial census and the American Community Survey (ACS). Among other purposes like apportionment of congressional seats, data gathered by the Census Bureau inform federal funding for programs across all levels of government and provide data used by governmental and nongovernmental entities for a variety of purposes. More information on the Census Bureau can be found in CRS Report R47847, *The U.S. Census Bureau: An Overview*.

Why and how might the Census Bureau contact my constituents?

In addition to contacts related to the decennial census, the Census Bureau may contact households, individuals, businesses, or governmental units for one of its numerous ongoing surveys, including but not limited to the ACS.[1]

The Census Bureau may contact constituents by official mailing, in-person contact, phone calls, and text messages.[2] The bureau is to provide the name of the survey to which it requests a constituent's response at first contact.[3]

Typically, in the first part of years ending in 0, households may be contacted by the Census Bureau to complete the decennial census of housing and population. During previous censuses, the bureau has mailed the questionnaire itself or a mailer requesting households to respond online to most addresses.[4] The bureau sends field staff to enumerate households that do not respond after the initial contact.[5]

How can my constituents tell if someone contacting them from the Census Bureau is legitimate?

The Census Bureau contacts respondents by mail, in-person contacts, email, telephone, and text message. The Census Bureau has established a web page (https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/surveyhelp/verify-a-survey.html) that provides guidance to potential survey respondents

[1] U.S. Census Bureau, "Are You in a Survey? Help for Survey Participants," https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/surveyhelp.html.

[2] U.S. Census Bureau, "How We Conduct Our Surveys," https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/surveyhelp/we-conduct-surveys.html.

[3] U.S. Census Bureau, "Verify a Census Bureau Survey, Mailing, or Contact," https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/surveyhelp/verify-a-survey.html; U.S. Census Bureau, "Are You in a Survey? Help for Survey Participants," https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/surveyhelp.html.

[4] U.S. Census Bureau, "About the 2010 Decennial Census," https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/decennial-census/decade/2010/about-2010.html; U.S. Census Bureau, "2020 Census Mailings," March 6, 2020, https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/decennial-census/decade/2020/planning-management/count/2020-census-mailings.html.

[5] CRS In Focus IF12909, *The Decennial Census of Population and Housing: An Overview*, by Taylor R. Knoedl.

to verify the legitimacy of a Census Bureau survey outreach.[6] The web page provides information on what respondents can look for and who they can contact in such circumstances.

Verify a Mailing

Individuals who receive a mailing can expect to see "U.S. Census Bureau" or "U.S. Department of Commerce" in the return address. Additionally, the Census Bureau has a mail processing center located in Jeffersonville, IN, which could appear on the return address. The Census Bureau also sends out reminder letters from its regional offices or its Washington DC-area headquarters.[7]

Verify an Email or Text Message

The Census Bureau may send text messages and emails to potential respondents with information or instructions to complete a survey. The bureau's guidance says these messages will not ask the respondent to provide any personal information directly by email or text. The bureau also explains that emails from the Census Bureau are sent from the bureau's official @census.gov domain.[8] Constituents may verify a text or email sender's legitimacy by searching the Census Bureau online staff database. Constituents may also reach out to their local Census Bureau Regional Office to verify a contact.[9]

Verify a Census Bureau Field Representative

The Census Bureau sometimes uses field representatives to collect responses door-to-door. These individuals are to carry a Census Bureau-branded bag and electronic device (laptop, tablet, smartphone) and have an identification badge that includes their name and photograph, an expiration date, and a Department of Commerce watermark.[10]

Verify a Phone Call

The Census Bureau uses two contact centers to reach out to respondents when conducting household surveys:

- Jeffersonville, IN—(812) 218-3144
- Tucson, AZ—(520) 798-4152

Respondents may see these phone numbers when they are contacted by the Census Bureau to complete a household survey. Respondents may verify that a call they receive is from the Census Bureau by calling one of three Census Bureau help centers:

- Jeffersonville, IN—(800) 523-3205

[6] U.S. Census Bureau, "Verify a Census Bureau Survey, Mailing, or Contact," https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/surveyhelp/verify-a-survey.html.

[7] U.S. Census Bureau, "Regional Offices," https://www.census.gov/about/regions.html; "Contact Us," https://www.census.gov/about/contact-us.html.

[8] U.S. Census Bureau, "Verify a Census Bureau Survey, Mailing, or Contact: Verify an Email or Text Message is from the Census Bureau."

[9] U.S. Census Bureau, "Census Bureau Staff Search," https://www.census.gov/staffsearch/; U.S. Census Bureau, "Verify a Census Bureau Survey, Mailing, or Contact: How to identify a Census Bureau field representative."

[10] U.S. Census Bureau, "Verify a Census Bureau Survey, Mailing, or Contact: How to identify a Census Bureau field representative."

- Tucson, AZ—(800) 642-0469
- Customer Service Center—(800) 923-8282

Field representatives may also call respondents from their Census Bureau-issued smartphones; constituents can confirm the identity of a field representative through the Census Bureau staff online database.[11]

Are my constituents required to respond to Census Bureau surveys? Are there consequences for not responding?

Some of the Census Bureau's data collection is mandatory under Title 13 of the *U.S. Code.*[12] Respondents are required by law to respond to the following:

- Decennial Census of Housing and Population,
- American Community Survey (ACS),
- Annual Business Survey (ABS),
- Annual Integrated Economic Survey (AEIS),
- Business and Professional Classification Report, and
- Economic Census.

Other surveys the Census Bureau conducts are voluntary.

Can the Census Bureau provide monetary incentives to survey respondents?

The Census Bureau has provided monetary incentives to survey respondents on occasion. For example, the bureau did this in the 1990s for the Survey of Income and Program Participation (SIPP) and the Survey of Program Dynamics.[13] Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) research found that introducing monetary incentives to survey respondents increased response rates.[14] Monetary incentives may be provided for other surveys as well.

[11] U.S. Census Bureau "Verify a Census Bureau Survey, Mailing, or Contact: How to identify a phone call from the Census Bureau;" U.S. Census Bureau, "Census Bureau Staff Search," https://www.census.gov/staffsearch/.

[12] Surveys established by 13 U.S.C. §§131-196; requirement to respond to certain surveys is established in 13 U.S.C. §§221, 224, and 225.

[13] Kathleen P. Creighton, Karen E. King, and Elizabeth A. Martin, *The Use of Monetary Incentives in Census Bureau Longitudinal Surveys*, U.S. Census Bureau, January 29, 2007, https://www.census.gov/content/dam/Census/library/working-papers/2007/adrm/rsm2007-02.pdf.

[14] David E. McGrath, *An Incentives Experiment in the U.S. Consumer Expenditure Quarterly Survey*, Bureau of Labor Statistics, December 2006, https://www.bls.gov/osmr/research-papers/2006/pdf/st060030.pdf.

What happens with my constituents' information after the Census Bureau collects it?

The Census Bureau says it keeps the information it collects on a secure computer server. Information that is released is to undergo *disclosure avoidance* techniques in which any personally identifiable information is removed and only aggregate statistics about people and businesses are published.[15] This "deidentified" and aggregated information is made publicly available in data tables at https://data.census.gov.

Policymakers, governments, researchers, businesses, and others utilize data from Census Bureau surveys for many purposes, including to inform various policy decisions, guide federal funding, offer public insights on population trends, and help the private sector to make informed business decisions.[16] Census data are used to determine allocation of funding for numerous federal programs, which amounted to more than $2.8 trillion in FY2021 according to Census Bureau estimates.[17]

The Census Bureau publishes data on a variety of population and economic characteristics, and it produces statistical products, including data tables, interactive visualizations, and reports. For more information, see CRS Report R47847, *The U.S. Census Bureau: An Overview* and "How can my constituents find Census Bureau data?"

How does the Census Bureau protect a respondent's privacy?

The Census Bureau is legally prohibited from disclosing identifiable information that it collects from respondents. By law, information collected during Census Bureau surveys can only be used for aggregated statistical purposes.[18] This means that Census Bureau employees who wrongfully disclose a respondent's information are subject to penalties.[19]

Specifically, Title 13, Section 9(a) of the *U.S. Code* states that the Secretary of Commerce, any officer or employee of the Department of Commerce or Census Bureau, or a local government census liaison may not

> (1) use the information furnished under the provisions of this title for any purpose other than the statistical purposes for which it is supplied; or
>
> (2) make any publication whereby the data furnished by any particular establishment or individual under this title can be identified; or

[15] U.S. Census Bureau, "American Community Survey Disclosure Avoidance," https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/methodology/disclosure-avoidance.html; Department of Commerce, *Disclosure Avoidance for Statistical Products*, DAO 216-26, June 4, 2026, https://www.commerce.gov/opog/disclosure-avoidance-statistical-products.

[16] U.S. Census Bureau, "Our Censuses," https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/censuses.html.

[17] Ceci Villa Ross, *Uses of Decennial Census Programs Data in Federal Funds Distribution: Fiscal Year 2021*, U.S. Census Bureau, June 2023, p. 2, https://www.census.gov/library/working-papers/2023/dec/census-data-federal-funds.html.

[18] 13 U.S.C. §9.

[19] 13 U.S.C. §214.

> (3) permit anyone other than the sworn officers and employees of the Department or bureau or agency thereof to examine the individual reports.[20]

Under federal law, individuals with access to sensitive information maintained by the Census Bureau are subject to penalties for wrongful disclosure of such information. Penalties established in Section 214 of Title 13 provide a maximum fine of $5,000, imprisonment of not more than five years, or both.[21] Section 3571(b) of Title 18 provides an alternative schedule of fines that may be applicable, raising the potential maximum penalty for a violation of Title 13 to $250,000.[22]

The Census Bureau explains that it takes steps to ensure that individual respondents cannot be identified through the statistics it publishes by using a *disclosure avoidance* system.[23]

However, the Census Bureau transfers information gathered during the decennial census to the National Archives and Records Administration (NARA) for permanent storage. NARA eventually releases information gathered during the decennial census under the "72-Year Rule." Established in P.L. 95-416, this rule allows decennial census data to be released to the general public 72 years after they are collected.[24]

What is the American Community Survey?

The American Community Survey (ACS) is the largest household survey administered by the Census Bureau. Each year, it samples 3.5 million residential addresses across the 50 states, the District of Columbia, and Puerto Rico.[25] The ACS is a long-form questionnaire that covers more than 40 topics, including education, employment, income, housing, and transportation.[26]

Typically, the Census Bureau initially contacts households by mail and requests that they complete a survey online, by mail or phone, or during an in-person interview.[27] If a household does not use one of these methods to respond, it may be contacted by an in-person interviewer.[28]

How is the American Community Survey different from the decennial census?

Table 1 below details the differing characteristics of the ACS and the decennial census.

[20] 13 U.S.C. §9(a).

[21] 13 U.S.C. §214.

[22] 18 U.S.C. §3571(b).

[23] U.S. Census Bureau, "Decennial Census of Population and Housing Disclosure Avoidance," https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/decennial-census/disclosure-avoidance.html.

[24] U.S. Census Bureau, "Public Can Access Census Records 72 Years After Each Decennial Census," https://www.census.gov/library/stories/2022/04/national-archives-releases-1950-census-records.html.

[25] CRS Insight IN12303, *The American Community Survey*, by Taylor R. Knoedl.

[26] U.S. Census Bureau, "American Community Survey (ACS)," https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs.html.

[27] U.S. Census Bureau, "Respond to the American Community Survey," https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/respond.html.

[28] U.S. Census Bureau, "Other Ways to Respond," https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/respond/other-ways-to-respond.html.

Table 1. Differences Between the American Community Survey and the Decennial Census

Characteristic	ACS	Decennial Census
Primary Purpose	Measure changing social and economic characteristics of population	Reapportionment
Survey Method	Sample of the population	Whole population enumeration
Question Content	Detailed demographic characteristics	Basic demographic information
Collection Frequency	Ongoing, monthly	Every 10 years
Data Collection Time Period Goal	Estimates collected over specified periods of time	Data collected from a single point in time

Source: U.S. Census Bureau, *Understanding and Using American Community Survey Data: What All Data Users Need to Know*, September 2020, https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/library/handbooks/general.html.

Note: This is not an exhaustive list of the differences between the two surveys.

What is the Household Trends and Outlooks Pulse Survey?

The Household Trends and Outlook Pulse Survey (HTOPS), formerly the Household Pulse Survey, is an experimental survey originally developed as an effort to quickly gather demographic information in response to the COVID-19 pandemic. The HTOPS aims to provide data with a relatively short turnaround time. Due to the survey's experimental nature and the faster turnaround time, HTOPS data products do not necessarily meet some of the Census Bureau's statistical quality standards.[29]

During May 2026, HTOPS sampled about 136,000 households, based on an assumed 10% response rate.[30] Survey topics include food and nutrition, transportation, and education. The bureau intends to use HTOPS data to improve and inform future surveys. Participation in HTOPS is voluntary.[31]

[29] U.S. Census Bureau, "Household Pulse Survey: Measuring Emergent Social and Economic Matters Facing U.S. Households," July 23, 2026, https://www.census.gov/data/experimental-data-products/household-pulse-survey.html.

[30] U.S. Census Bureau, *Source of the Data and Accuracy of the Household Trends and Outlook Pulse Survey (HTOPS) Data Collection of March 2026*, https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/demo/technical-documentation/hhp/HTOPS_2603_Source_and_Accuracy.pdf; U.S. Census Bureau, "Tip Sheet Number 16—August 7, 2026," August 6, 2026, https://www.census.gov/newsroom/tip-sheets/2026/tp26-16.html.

[31] U.S. Census Bureau, "Household Trends and Outlook Pulse Survey (HTOPS)," https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/htops.html.

There has been a considerable change in population in my state or district since the last decennial census. Can the Census Bureau conduct a new count to address this change?

Some constituents may have concerns about the timeliness of certain Census data. For example, constituents may have observed significant changes in local or regional areas between decennial censuses. In this scenario, constituents may consider discussing the Special Census Program with local officials. A special census is a basic enumeration of population, housing units, group quarters, and transitory locations that the Census Bureau can conduct at the request of a governmental unit. Local officials may consider requesting a special census or a smaller partial special census if they believe there has been considerable population size or demographic change in their community.[32]

For the bureau to conduct a special census, the given state's legislation must allow it. Also, only the following functioning governmental unit types are eligible for a special census:

- tribal areas, including federally recognized tribes with a reservation and/or off-reservation trust lands, Alaska Native Regional Corporations, and Alaska Native villages;
- states or equivalent entities (e.g., District of Columbia, Puerto Rico);
- counties or equivalent entities (e.g., boroughs, parishes, municipios);
- minor civil divisions (e.g., townships);
- consolidated cities; and
- incorporated places (e.g., villages, towns, cities).[33]

The bureau conducts special censuses on a cost-reimbursement basis, which means that the governmental unit requesting the special census is responsible for the full cost associated with conducting the count and is to reimburse the Census Bureau for all costs it incurs. The Census Bureau is to conduct a special census cost estimate before agreeing to conduct a special census and commencing any associated work.[34] Interested jurisdictions may complete the SC-900 Special Census Cost Estimate Request form to begin this process.[35]

While a special census can provide updated population estimates for a community, it cannot review or recount results from a previous census.[36]

[32] U.S. Census Bureau, "Special Census Program," https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/specialcensus.html.

[33] U.S. Census Bureau, "Special Census Program."

[34] U.S. Census Bureau, "Special Census Program."

[35] U.S. Census Bureau, *Form SC-900: SPECIAL CENSUS COST ESTIMATE REQUEST FORM*, https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/special-census/sc-900.pdf.

[36] U.S. Census Bureau, "Special Census Program."

The urban or rural classification of a community in my state or district has changed under Census Bureau delineations, potentially changing its eligibility for certain federal funding. Can this be changed?

The Census Bureau has an established urban and rural classification that is re-delineated after each decennial census. Re-delineation attempts to ensure that the classification of places across the nation reflects population changes.[37]

During the re-delineation process, the Census Bureau seeks feedback from stakeholders through the *Federal Register*.[38] There is no other formal process by which the bureau changes urban and rural delineations outside of the existing decennial census cycle.

In establishing these delineations, the Census Bureau considers only their use for statistical purposes. The Census Bureau does not attempt to consider or meet the requirements of nonstatistical uses of urban and rural delineations or any associated data.[39]

Some legislation may define rural and urban differently than the Census Bureau.[40] Additionally, other geographic delineations exist across the federal government, including core based statistical areas developed by the Office of Management and Budget (OMB).[41]

How can my constituents find Census Bureau data?

There are several ways constituents can access Census Bureau data. Most publicly available data can be found at https://data.census.gov/. Additionally, the Census Bureau maintains a library of publications using Census data online at https://www.census.gov/library.html.[42] Decennial census data are also released 72 years after they were collected, available online through NARA at https://www.archives.gov/research/census/online-resources.[43] Restricted-use, confidential data may be accessed at a federal statistical research data center. Constituents must complete an application process to access such data.[44]

Data about congressional districts is made available online through the My Congressional District tool.[45]

---

[37] U.S. Census Bureau, "Urban and Rural," https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/geography/guidance/geo-areas/urban-rural.html.

[38] U.S. Census Bureau, "Urban Areas for the 2020 Census-Proposed Criteria," 86 *Federal Register* 10237, February 19, 2021, https://www.federalregister.gov/documents/2021/02/19/2021-03412/urban-areas-for-the-2020-census-proposed-criteria.

[39] U.S. Census Bureau, "Urban Area Criteria for the 2020 Census-Final Criteria," 87 *Federal Register* 16706, March 24, 2022, p. 7, https://www.federalregister.gov/documents/2022/03/24/2022-06180/urban-area-criteria-for-the-2020-census-final-criteria#p-7.

[40] For some such examples, see CRS Report R47510, *Rural Definitions Used for Eligibility Requirements in USDA Rural Development Programs*, coordinated by Lisa S. Benson.

[41] CRS In Focus IF12704, *Core Based Statistical Areas*, by Taylor R. Knoedl.

[42] U.S. Census Bureau, "Library," https://www.census.gov/library.html.

[43] U.S. Census Bureau, "Public Census Records," https://www.census.gov/about/history/census-records-family-history/census-records.html.

[44] U.S. Census Bureau, "Federal Statistical Research Data Centers," https://www.census.gov/about/adrm/fsrdc.html.

[45] U.S. Census Bureau, "My Congressional District," https://www.census.gov/mycd/.

Are there any employment opportunities available at the Census Bureau that may be relevant for my constituents?

Employment opportunities are available on the Census Bureau's website.[46] Permanent employment may be available at the Census Bureau headquarters located in Suitland, MD; locations in one of the six regions across the United States; or the National Processing Center facilities located in Arizona and Indiana.

The Census Bureau also often hires temporary positions for enumerators during the decennial census, as well as any census tests leading up to the decennial census.

Author Information

Taylor R. Knoedl
Analyst in American National Government

Disclaimer

This document was prepared by the Congressional Research Service (CRS). CRS serves as nonpartisan shared staff to congressional committees and Members of Congress. It operates solely at the behest of and under the direction of Congress. Information in a CRS Report should not be relied upon for purposes other than public understanding of information that has been provided by CRS to Members of Congress in connection with CRS's institutional role. CRS Reports, as a work of the United States Government, are not subject to copyright protection in the United States. Any CRS Report may be reproduced and distributed in its entirety without permission from CRS. However, as a CRS Report may include copyrighted images or material from a third party, you may need to obtain the permission of the copyright holder if you wish to copy or otherwise use copyrighted material.

[46] U.S. Census Bureau, "Census Careers," https://www.census.gov/about/census-careers.html.